

SMART INDIA HACKATHON (SIH) 2026

VIT Bibwewadi and Kondhwa Campus Internal Hackathon and Team Selection

Rules, Guidelines & Frequently Asked Questions

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1. GENERAL RULES & ELIGIBILITY

Q: Who is eligible to participate?

A: Any student currently enrolled at VIT Pune (both campuses Bibwewadi and Kondhwa) in Second Year (SY), Third Year (TY), or Final Year can participate. Teams can be formed with members from the same or different years.

Q: What is the minimum and maximum team size?

A: 6 members per team in which atleast **ONE** Female member is compulsory.
A team can be formed with any student of any branch of any year of VIT Pune.

Q: Can a student be part of multiple teams?

A: No. Once a student is registered as part of a team, they cannot register with another team in the same selection round. This ensures fair allocation of talent across teams.

2. REGISTRATION & TEAM FORMATION

Q: How do I register my team?

A: Registration will open after the official SIH 2026 problem statements are released (expected mid-August). A centralized google form will be shared. One team member (preferably the team lead) should complete the internal hackathon registration with all required team details. Students don't need to do registration anywhere. Your registration on SIH will be done by SPOC if you are in top 50 teams of VIT Pune.

Q: What documents do I need to submit during registration?

A: You will need to provide: (1) Team member names, email IDs, and PR numbers; (2) Problem statement IDs chosen (max 2); (3) A brief team introduction. Exact requirements will be listed in form.

3. PROBLEM STATEMENTS & PS SELECTION

Q: Where can I find the problem statements?

A: Problem statements will be published on the official SIH 2026 website and also shared through VIT campus channels (email, portal) once released (mid-August). You can browse all available PS and choose the ones that match your interests.

Q: Can I choose my own problem instead of the ones listed?

A: No. For this internal selection, you must choose from the official SIH 2026 problem statements. Custom problems are not permitted at this stage.

Q: Can my team register for more than one problem statement?

A: Yes. Each team can register for a maximum of 2 problem statements. This gives you flexibility to pitch different ideas based on your team's interests and skills.

Q: If my team is shortlisted for both problem statements, which one do we present in Round 2?

A: You must choose only one PS to present in Round 2. If your team qualifies in both, you will be notified after Round 1 results and given a deadline to declare your choice. The other PS slot will be released for other teams.

4. INTERNAL HACKATHON ROUND 1: ONLINE IDEA PITCH

Q: When Round 1 may happen?

A: Proposed dates are in mid-August (probably 20th to 27th August)

Q: What happens in Round 1?

A: All registered teams (that may be around 1,000) will pitch their ideas live (in online meeting) to a panel of judges. Each team gets 15 minutes to present their idea and 5 minutes for answer questions. Judges will score your pitch against a standard rubric.

Q: Do I need to submit anything before my Round 1 pitch?

A: Yes. Along with your team details the problem statement and ideas need to submit with a supporting presentation ppt (max 6 pages). Idea presentation ppt should be as per provided SIH template.

Q: When will I know my scheduled idea pitch time?

A: After registration closes, the coordinators will schedule all teams into time slots across judges. The schedule will be shared at least 3-5 days before Round 1 begins. You cannot reschedule without prior approval from the SIH coordinators/SPOC.

Q: How many teams advance to Round 2?

A: Approx 300 teams will advance to Round 2 based on their Round 1 scores. This cap is strictly enforced, even if multiple teams score similarly. Tie-break criteria will be pre-defined.

Q: When will Round 1 results be announced?

A: Results will be announced within 2-3 days after Round 1 ends (by end of August or early September). Shortlisted teams will receive a notification.

5. INTERNAL HACKATHON ROUND 2: OFFLINE FINAL PRESENTATION

Q: Where and when is Round 2?

A: Round 2 is held in-person (offline) on a single day i.e. 24hrs in the first week of September. Most probably on 3rd September. The venue and exact date will be announced after Round 1 results. All presentations happen on VIT B campus in designated seminar halls/classrooms/labs.

Q: How much time does each team get to present in Round 2?

A: Each team gets 15 minutes for their presentation. This includes time for the pitch and Q&A from the judges. Strict time management is enforced to keep the day on schedule.

Q: What should I include in my Round 2 presentation?

A: The presentation should align with standard template of SIH. Your presentation should include: (1) Problem understanding and relevance; (2) Your proposed solution with technical details; (3) Feasibility and implementation roadmap; (4) Expected impact and scalability; (5) Team roles and capabilities; (6) A mock-up, prototype, or proof-of-concept if possible. Quality and clarity matter - use slides effectively.

Q: How many teams are finally selected from VIT?

A: 45 teams will be selected, plus 5 teams will be placed on a waiting list. Waiting-listed teams may be selected if any of the top 45 withdraw or face disqualification. Only finalized 50 team's registration will be done on SIH 2026 portal.

6. EVALUATION CRITERIA & JUDGING

Q: How will my team be judged?

A: All teams are evaluated using a standard rubric with 7 criteria:

- Problem Understanding - How well you understand and articulate the issue
- Innovation - Novelty and creativity of your proposed solution
- Technical Feasibility - Whether your idea can realistically be implemented
- Practical Impact - Real-world usefulness, scalability, and expected benefits
- Presentation Quality - Clarity, confidence, and structure of your communication

Q: Who are the judges?

A: Judges are alumni and industry professionals with strong technical expertise. They are completely independent of internal college coordinators/representatives. Current faculty members do not judge to ensure unbiased evaluation.

Q: Will there be bias or favouritism in judging?

A: No. Multiple safeguards are in place: (1) Judges are external (alumni & industry, not faculty); (2) No recent alumni from the 2026, 2025, 2014 batch judge to avoid knowing participants; (3) A standard rubric is used by all judges; (4) Multiple judges evaluate multiple teams to ensure consistency.

7. FEEDBACK & TRANSPARENCY

Q: Will I get feedback if my team is not shortlisted?

A: Yes. Every team (shortlisted or not) will receive their marking sheet with scores and written remarks from judges. This feedback is meant to help you improve for future hackathons and competitions.

Q: How detailed will the feedback be?

A: Judges are required to provide constructive remarks beyond just scores. They will note strengths (what worked well) and areas for improvement. This feedback is shared via a marking sheet sent to your team leader within days of Round 2.

Q: When can I see the final results?

A: Final results and shortlists will be on the same day

Q: Can I appeal against the judging decision?

A: The selection process is final once results are announced. However, if you believe there was a procedural error (e.g., a judge conflict of interest, a technical glitch during your pitch), you can file a formal complaint within 24 hrs of results announcement to the SIH coordination team.

8. MENTORSHIP & WORKSHOPS

Q: Will my team will get mentorship from previous SIH winners?

A: Yes. It is planned to have orientation and mentorship sessions for all SIH participants.

Q: Will there be workshops to prepare for the hackathon?

A: Yes! Pre-Round 1 awareness sessions and workshops will be conducted in August by previous SIH winners and industry experts. Topics include: idea framing, pitching skills, technical approach development, and common mistakes to avoid.

Q: How do I register for the workshops/sessions?

A: Workshop invitations and registration links will be shared via Telegram Group <https://t.me/+EsFh82GRBMozYzI1> . Attendance is not mandatory but highly recommended to improve your chances and polish your pitch/ideas.

Q: Will shortlisted teams get mentorship after selection?

A: Yes! All 45 selected teams will be assigned mentors (previous SIH winners or industry experts) who will guide you on refining your solution, technical development, and preparing for the national-level SIH competition. Mentorship begins immediately after the final list is announced.

For More Information

Contact the VIT SIH SPOC, Dr Vikas Kolekar and SIH Coordination Team.
Also regularly visit the official SIH portal for updates.

Good luck!